

Notes for Political Science Graduate Students: Making the Most of Visiting Scholar Meetings

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One-on-one meetings and breakfasts with visiting scholars are opportunities to exchange ideas, get feedback, and learn about academic life. Approach them with curiosity and something you would like to discuss. You might pitch an emerging idea, work through a research challenge, or ask about the profession more generally—how people choose projects, find mentors, and navigate graduate school.

What to expect

Breakfasts are usually informal group conversations. The visitor may discuss their paper, but they will often ask students about their interests. Participate, listen, and make room for others. A one-on-one meeting gives you more space to discuss your work and seek focused advice. Both formats can lead to useful conversations even when the visitor's research differs from yours.

How to prepare

Read the circulated paper, learn about the visitor's broader interests, and prepare a few questions. Choose one or two things you would like to learn, and be ready to introduce yourself and your research. Early in the PhD, interests, puzzles, and possible directions are enough to discuss.

Prepare an elevator pitch

An **elevator pitch** is a brief, accessible explanation of who you are, what interests you, and why it matters. Its purpose is to give someone enough context to understand your work and begin a conversation. A useful pitch includes:

1. **Who you are:** Your program, stage, and broad research interests.
2. **Your central question:** What are you trying to understand? Start with the big picture.
3. **Why it matters:** What makes the question consequential or puzzling?
4. **One or two concrete details:** Depending on your stage, describe a possible project, your argument, your approach, or a key finding.
5. **An opening for discussion:** What are you still figuring out, and where would feedback help?

Be concise: keep your prepared pitch to two or three minutes. Write it down and practice aloud. Then pause so the visitor can ask follow-up questions, offer feedback, and help the conversation develop naturally. If someone asks a question sooner, follow their interest; you can return to other details as needed. Keep additional explanation ready for follow-ups, and allow the exchange to flow.

An early-stage example

A short opening might sound like this:

"I'm a first-year PhD student interested in political economy and technological change. I'm especially curious about how communities respond to data centers, and why similar projects generate support in some places and opposition in others. I'm still narrowing the question and would welcome suggestions about how to frame it."

A more advanced example

Here is an adaptation of my own dissertation-stage pitch:

"I'm Valentina, a PhD candidate in political science at the University of Pittsburgh. My research lies at the intersection of international political economy and comparative politics.

I study how technological change reshapes political behavior and party competition. My dissertation asks how and to what extent economic polarization—a shrinking middle class—fuels political polarization, including declining support for moderate parties and candidates.

In one project, I examine how right-wing populist parties win support from workers threatened by automation, and how electoral institutions shape their strategies. In another, I investigate whether cultural grievances help explain the relationship between automation risk and support for the populist right. I combine formal modeling, survey experiments, and analysis of political texts to explore these questions."

These examples provide a starting point; your pitch can become more specific as your research develops. You can end by naming the input you would value: “I’d especially appreciate your thoughts on the mechanism I’m proposing.” You do not need to fill the entire two or three minutes if a shorter introduction starts a useful conversation.

Questions to have ready

Choose questions that fit what you hope to learn:

- “What would help make this research question more focused?”
- “What alternative explanation should I consider?”
- “Are there readings or data sources you would recommend?”
- “How did you develop the idea behind your paper?”
- “How do you decide which projects to pursue?”
- “What advice would you give someone at my stage of the PhD?”
- “Which skills should graduate students prioritize as AI changes research?”

You can also say, “I’m still exploring my interests and would appreciate hearing how yours developed.” A worthwhile meeting can help you sharpen a project, discover a new direction, or simply understand the profession a little better.